forward and they occupied hitherto unoccupied heights along the Tsogtsalu to maintain parity of forces, and to contain the PLA. The strength at KS Hill was also beefed up. While the Infantry had no problems moving up, the mechanized column faced some difficulties due to a lack of proper surface connectivity.

The situation on the North Bank of the Pangong Tso was slightly different. Pangong Lake, situated at a height of almost 4350 m, is the world's highest saltwater lake. Its waters, which seem to be dyed in blue, stand in stark contrast to the arid mountains surrounding it. Extending to almost 160 km, one-third of the Pangong Lake lies in India and the other two-thirds in Tibet.[13] From the mountains surrounding it, particularly to the North, are a number of ridges that slope gradually towards the lake. These spurs, or fingers as they are more commonly called, are numbered from 1 through 8 starting from the Indian side. Thus Finger 1, Finger 2 and so on to Finger 8. This is one of the areas where there exists a difference in perception as to where the LAC runs since it has never been delineated nor demarcated. It is thus a kind of 'No Man's Land'—while we, the Indian Army (IA) would patrol up to Finger 8, the PLA would do so up to Finger 4, with either side contesting this activity and lodging protests at the appropriate level. At times, this too would result in the proverbial face-off and resultant jostling and pushing.

This was quite a routine activity, and the same was the case on 18/19 May when the patrols faced off, somewhere between Finger 4 and Finger 8. While the prescribed drill was being observed by the IA as per protocols, to defuse the situation, a large column of vehicles suddenly appeared from the direction of Sirijap Fort, past Finger 8 and up to the face of the site, disgorging not the usual Border Defence Regiment troops (akin

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